

CHAPTER 4

Early Humans and Beginning of Civilisation

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answers. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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The Big Questions

1 How did humans live on Earth before the beginning of civilisation?

✔ ANSWER

- In the Palaeolithic period they were hunter–gatherers using stone tools like handaxes, cleavers and scrapers; they lived in caves or open camps.
- In the Mesolithic period they used microlithic (tiny stone) tools, fished and gathered aquatic food, and painted rock shelters (e.g. Bhimbetka).
- In the Neolithic period they domesticated plants and animals, made pottery and set up the first villages.

2 How did humans communicate before writing was invented?

✔ ANSWER

- Through symbolic communication: paintings on the walls of caves and rock shelters.
- By engraving symbols on bones and shells (such as ostrich eggs) with a burin.
- By decorating their bodies with pigments and wearing beads of stone, bone and shell.

3 **How is archaeology helpful in understanding our past?**

✔ ANSWER

- More than 99 per cent of human history has no writing, so it is known mainly from archaeological evidence.
- Archaeologists dig up tools, bones, fossils, pottery and other objects; each clue builds a picture of how people lived.
- They also make and use similar tools to learn how early humans used them.

4 **How did early civilisations interact with each other?**

✔ ANSWER

- Mainly through trade. Mesopotamia and the Harappan region were close, so they had strong contacts.
- Sargon's tablets mention trade with Dilmun (Bahrain), Magan (Oman) and Meluhha (the Sindhu–Sarasvatī civilisation).
- They traded semiprecious stone beads, ivory, timber, gold dust and probably copper.
- Egypt and China have little tangible evidence of direct contact with the Harappans.

⭐ Let's Explore · The Harappan script

1 **Observe the Harappan seal (Fig. 4.1) and discuss why the script has not yet been deciphered. Also, find out what efforts have been made to decipher it.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Why not deciphered:

- The inscriptions on seals are very short (only a few signs each).
- No bilingual inscription has been found (like the Rosetta Stone, which helped read Egyptian).
- We do not know which language the Harappans spoke.

Efforts:

- Scholars have listed and compared all known signs (e.g. Iravatham Mahadevan, Asko Parpola).
- Computers are used to study how often signs appear and in what order.
- Many decipherment claims have been made, but none is accepted by all scholars yet.

🤔 Think About It · Why Should We Study Early Human History?

1 **Why do you think early humans left Africa to migrate to other regions?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- To find more food: they followed animals they hunted and searched for new plants.
- Changes in climate and environment made some areas dry or difficult to live in.
- Growing numbers of people needed new land and resources.
- Better stone tools (handaxes, cleavers) helped them survive in new places.

⭐ Let's Explore · Who Were Our Human Ancestors?

1 **Observe the skulls in Fig. 4.6. Do you notice any changes in the shape or features of the skulls across different ancestors?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes. From Homo habilis to Homo sapiens:

- The braincase becomes larger and more rounded.
- The jaws and teeth become smaller and the face less pushed forward.
- The heavy brow ridge above the eyes becomes smaller. (Check the pictures in your book.)

2 **Can you observe a gradual straightening of the face?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes. The face of early ancestors sticks out forward; over time it becomes flatter and more upright, and in Homo sapiens it is almost straight below a high forehead.

🤔 Think About It · Periods in Early Human History

1 **Why do you think the shift to farming during the Neolithic period is called a revolution rather than a simple change?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- It changed the whole way of life: from hunting and gathering food to producing food.
- People domesticated plants and animals, made pottery and settled in the first villages.
- Surplus food allowed more people, new crafts and later towns (the urban revolution).

Such a big, lasting change is called a revolution.

🤔 Think About It · The Neolithic Revolution

1 **Observe the chart (Fig. 4.14) and identify the animals that were domesticated. Also try and identify the types of human habitats and objects that were used. Are any of these still used in present times?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Animals: cattle (including the humped bull) and pigs (in China).
- Habitats: huts with thatched roofs and mud/brick houses in settled villages (sedentism).
- Objects: clay pots and baskets, digging tools/hoes for cultivation, crop fields (wheat, barley, millets, rice).
- Yes, thatched huts, clay pots, baskets, hoes and cattle are still used in many Indian villages today.

🤔 Think About It · Sindhu–Sarasvatī Civilisation

1 **Harappans used standard cubical stone weights (binary multiples 1, 2, 4, 8, 16... for small units; multiples of ten for larger ones). Can you imagine how long-distance trade would have been affected had the Harappans not followed a standard system of weights?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Traders in different places would measure goods differently, causing confusion and quarrels.
- Cheating would be easy and people would not trust each other.
- Fixing fair prices and exchanging goods over long distances would be slow and difficult.

So trade would have been much smaller and less efficient.

🤔 Think About It · Bronze Age Civilisations Outside India

1 **Why were rivers important in the growth of early civilisations?**

✔ ANSWER

- They gave water for drinking and for irrigating fields.
- Floods left fertile soil (e.g. 'kemet' along the Nile), so farmers grew surplus food.
- Surplus food supported cities, crafts and trade.
- Rivers were also routes for transport and trade.

⭐ Let's Explore · Mesopotamian Civilisation

1 **Can you find out which countries constitute West Asia in present times?**

✔ ANSWER

Main countries: Turkey, Syria, Lebanon, Israel, Jordan, Iraq, Iran, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Bahrain, Qatar, United Arab Emirates, Oman and Yemen (Cyprus, Georgia, Armenia and Azerbaijan are also often included).

2 **Do you find any similarities between the temples in India and those of the Sumerian civilisation as centres of socio-cultural and economic activity?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes:

- Both were built as grand temples for gods, and towns often grew around them.
- Sumerian ziggurats controlled farming, trade and storage; many Indian temples also owned land, stored wealth and gave work to many people.
- Both were centres of festivals, music and social life, with priests holding a high position.

🔭 Let Us Recall · The Beginning of Writing

1 **Cuneiform has been deciphered but the Harappan script has not. Do you think our understanding of a civilisation changes when its script is deciphered compared to when it is not?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes. Without a readable script we know a civilisation only from objects, so dates are approximate and thoughts are hard to know.

Deciphered cuneiform tells us names, myths, epics, hymns, law codes and records of farming and crafts. Reading the Harappan script could similarly tell us their language, rulers, beliefs and trade.

⭐ Let's Explore · The Akkadians

1 **The Epic of Gilgamesh is one of the earliest stories written. Try and find out more such stories and share them in class.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Some very old stories:

- The Rigveda hymns and later the Ramayana and Mahabharata (India).
- The story of 'Sindbad the Sailor' and early forms of 'Cinderella' (from Egyptian papyrus, as the chapter mentions).
- The Panchatantra animal fables (India) and Aesop's Fables (Greece).
- Homer's Iliad and Odyssey (Greece).

🤔 Think About It · Egyptian Civilisation

1 **Why do you think there is a scale with a heart on one side and a feather on the other (Fig. 4.29)? What can this papyrus tell us about early Egyptian beliefs?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- It shows the judgement of a dead person: the heart is weighed against a feather (standing for truth and justice).
- If the heart was light (a good life), the person could enter the afterlife; if heavy, it was eaten by a monster.
- So Egyptians believed in life after death, in gods who judged people, and in living a good, honest life.

⭐ Let's Map · Egyptian Civilisation

1 **Can you locate the River Nile on the given map (Fig. 4.30)? Why do you think the northern part is called Lower Egypt and the southern part Upper Egypt?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- The Nile flows from south to north through Egypt and enters the Mediterranean Sea near Giza/Heliopolis (check the map in your book).
- The south is upstream and higher land, so it is Upper Egypt; the north is downstream, near the sea and lower, so it is Lower Egypt.

⭐ Let's Explore · Social hierarchy in Egypt

1 **Look at the social hierarchy pyramid (Fig. 4.32): Pharaoh → Government officials,**

nobles and priests → Free landholders, artisans and merchants → Serfs and slaves.

What were the social classes of early Egypt? What were the different kinds of occupations? What could have been a typical daily routine of the people from each class?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Class	Occupation	Daily routine (likely)
Pharaoh	Ruler	Meeting officials, giving orders, leading rituals and festivals
Officials, nobles, priests	Administration, temples	Collecting taxes, keeping records, performing temple worship
Free landholders, artisans, merchants	Farming, crafts, trade	Working fields, making pots/cloth/jewellery, buying and selling
Serfs and slaves	Labour	Hard work in fields, building dams, ditches and pyramids

🤔 Think About It · Daily items of the Egyptians

1. Observe Fig. 4.33 (a painted pot, a woven basket and woven sandals). What do they tell you about Egyptian fashion?

Which social classes do you think used these items?

What clues in the images help you to make this guess?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Fashion: Egyptians wore light, woven sandals (suited to a hot climate) and used decorated pots and neat baskets; they valued skilled, neat craftwork.
- The plain woven sandals and baskets, made from local plants (papyrus/reeds), could be used by ordinary free people; the finely painted pot may belong to richer people such as nobles or priests.
- Clues: the materials (cheap plant fibre vs. painted pottery), the fine designs and the amount of work needed. (Check the pictures in your book.)

⭐ The Chinese Civilisation

? **You have already seen in the case of Mesopotamia and Egypt how rivers helped civilisations grow. Can you recall how they supported people's lives?**

✔ ANSWER

- Euphrates and Tigris: canals and dams for irrigation helped farming spread across the plains.

- Nile: yearly floods left rich black mud ('kemet'); ditches and reservoirs stored water; counting days between floods gave a calendar.
- Rivers gave water, fertile land, surplus food and routes for trade.

⭐ Let's Explore · Chinese script

1 **The Chinese script is logographic (e.g. 人 person, 木 tree). Note down at least two more characters that resemble the objects or ideas they represent and explain how their shapes are connected to their meanings.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- 山 (mountain): three peaks rising from the ground.
- 日 (sun): first drawn as a circle with a dot; now a box with a line.
- 口 (mouth): an open mouth shape.
- 林 (forest): two 木 (trees) side by side = many trees.

🤔 Think About It · The Great Wall of China

1 **What could have been the other reasons for building the Great Wall of China? Explore and share your findings through a model or presentation.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Besides protection from nomadic raids:

- To mark and control the border of the empire.
- To control trade and collect taxes from traders and travellers (e.g. on the Silk Route).
- Watchtowers to send signals (smoke/fire) and move soldiers quickly.
- To show the power of the rulers.

Present this using a cardboard/clay model with watchtowers and labels.

⭐ Let's Recall · Silk Route

1 **Do you remember studying about the Silk Route in Grade 7? How was India connected with it? Can you recollect China's contact with India with reference to Buddhism?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Branches of the Silk Route passed through northwest India (Gandhara/Kashmir region) and linked to Indian ports; India traded cotton cloth, spices, gems and other goods.

- Buddhism spread from India to China along these routes; Buddhist monks and scholars travelled both ways, and Chinese pilgrims such as Faxian (Fa-Hien) and Xuanzang came to India to study Buddhism.

? Questions and activities

1 **Do you think life became easier or more challenging after humans started farming? Give two reasons for your answer.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Both, but mostly easier:

- Easier: food was more reliable and surplus could be stored; people lived in permanent villages.
- Easier: surplus allowed new crafts, pottery and trade.
- Challenging: hard work in fields, risk from droughts/floods and storing food safely.

2 **The environment offers human societies both opportunities as well as challenges. Explain with reference to early farming communities and river-valley civilisations.**

✔ ANSWER

Opportunities:

- After about 12000 years ago, a warmer climate spread forests and grasslands with more food.
- River plains (Nile, Euphrates–Tigris, Indus, Huang He) gave water and fertile soil for surplus crops.

Challenges:

- Floods and dry seasons; people had to build dams, canals, ditches and reservoirs (e.g. Sumerian canals, gabarbands, Dholavira tanks).
- Environmental degradation and pressure on land weakened Babylon.

3 **Why do historians divide early human history into different ages such as Stone Age, Bronze Age, and Iron Age? What does this classification tell us about human progress?**

✔ ANSWER

- The periods are based on technological progress: the main material used for tools, the beginning of agriculture and changes in lifestyle and settlement.
- It shows progress from simple stone tools (hunting–gathering) to polished stone tools and farming, then copper, bronze (towns, trade, civilisations) and iron (stronger tools, more advanced societies).

- Each new technology helped humans use natural resources better.

4 **Imagine you are a Neolithic farmer. Describe one day of your life. What challenges would you face that a hunter-gatherer would not?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

I wake up in my mud-brick house in the village, feed our sheep, goats and cattle, and go with polished stone tools to sow and weed the wheat and barley fields. My family grinds grain and makes clay pots. In the evening we store grain in the granary.

Challenges a hunter-gatherer would not face:

- Waiting months for the harvest and losing crops to drought, floods, pests or animals.
- Protecting stored grain and herds from thieves and animals.
- Staying in one place, so diseases and quarrels over land increase.

5 **Imagine that the Harappan script gets deciphered tomorrow. What new types of information do you think historians might learn?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

- The Harappan language and names of people, cities and rulers.
- Their beliefs, gods and stories.

- How they were governed and what their laws were.
- Details of trade, such as goods, prices and partners like Mesopotamia.
- More accurate dates of events.

6 **Prepare a table with three columns—Palaeolithic, Mesolithic, and Neolithic—and fill in their distinctive features: tools, settlements, art, and subsistence.**

✔ ANSWER

Feature	Palaeolithic	Mesolithic	Neolithic
Tools	Handaxes, cleavers, choppers, scrapers; later blades, bow and arrow	Microliths (tiny stone tools) fixed in handles	Polished stone tools for farming and food processing
Settlements	Caves or open camps	Caves, rock shelters, temporary camps near rivers and lakes	Permanent villages, mud-brick houses, granaries
Art	Cave paintings, body pigments, beads (late period)	Art flourished: painted rock shelters (Bhimbetka)	Pottery in many shapes, ornaments of semi-precious stones

Subsistence	Hunting and gathering	Hunting small game, fishing, gathering wild grains	Farming and domestication of animals

7 **"Bronze Age civilisations developed independently but shared common features." Examine this statement with reference to the civilisations given in the chapter.**

✔ ANSWER

Independent: the Harappan, Mesopotamian, Egyptian and Chinese civilisations grew separately in their own river plains; Egypt and China show little direct contact with the Harappans.

Common features:

- Grew in fertile river valleys with surplus farming.
- Used bronze metallurgy; had cities, crafts and trade.
- Had writing systems (Harappan script, cuneiform, hieroglyphs, Chinese script).
- Had rulers, administration and a social hierarchy.
- Built great structures (ziggurats, pyramids, Great Wall, Harappan planned cities).

8 **Although rivers provided many benefits, they also created challenges for early societies.**

Discuss both the advantages and disadvantages of settling near rivers.

✔ ANSWER

Advantages:

- Water for drinking and irrigation; fertile soil from floods.
- Surplus food, growth of cities; easy transport and trade.

Disadvantages:

- Floods could destroy homes and crops; rivers could change course or dry up.
- Needed hard collective work to build dams, ditches and canals.
- Rich river lands attracted attacks from others.

9 **With the help of your teacher, find out more about the Code of Hammurabi. Why was it important? Do you think it was fair to all sections of society? Give reasons for your answer.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- It was a set of rules for civil and social conduct compiled by King Hammurabi of Babylon (ruled from 1792 BCE), inscribed in cuneiform on a stone stele.

- Important: it was one of the earliest written law codes, made laws the same across the empire, and served as a model for many later legal systems.
- Not fully fair: punishments depended on social class (nobles, free people and slaves were treated differently), and many punishments were very harsh ('an eye for an eye').

10 **If you had to choose one major innovation from early civilisations that changed the world permanently, what would it be and why?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Writing (e.g. Sumerian cuneiform, about 3200 BCE).

- It let people keep records of trade, farming and laws.
- It preserved stories, hymns and knowledge for later generations.
- It marks the start of the historical period; without it, no books, schools or modern science.

11 **Compare the social hierarchy and daily life of people in the Egyptian civilisation with those in Mesopotamia or China. What similarities and differences do you notice?**

✔ ANSWER

Similarities:

- All had a ruler at the top and a ruling class/nobles, with farmers and labourers below.
- Most people were farmers; crafts and trade existed; religion was very important.

Differences:

- Egypt: the Pharaoh was supreme; serfs and slaves at the bottom; women could own property and run businesses; festivals like the Sed festival; leisure such as swimming, board games, music.
- Mesopotamia: life centred on the city temple (ziggurat); high priests and priestesses and scribes had high status.
- China: Zhou kings were also priests and could be dismissed if people did not prosper; officials were chosen by examination.

12 **Activity: Using maps, locate the major rivers and civilisations of Mesopotamia, Egypt, China, and the Sindhu–Sarasvatī Valley. Mark the trade links between them.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Mesopotamia: Euphrates and Tigris rivers (Iraq) – Ur, Uruk, Babylon, Assur.
- Egypt: River Nile – Memphis, Giza, Saqqara.
- China: Huang He (Yellow River) and Yangtze.
- Sindhu–Sarasvatī: Indus and Ghaggar–Sarasvatī – Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira, Lothal.
- Trade link: draw a line by sea along the Persian Gulf from Lothal/Mohenjo-daro via Magan (Oman) and Dilmun (Bahrain) to Ur (see Fig. 4.26). Little evidence of direct links with Egypt and China.

13 **Activity: Choose one early civilisation (Mesopotamia, Egypt, or China) and prepare a mini-scrapbook or a presentation showing their innovations in tools, writing, art, and architecture.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Example – Egypt:

- Tools/technology: ditches, dams and reservoirs for Nile water; a 365-day calendar.
- Writing: hieroglyphs on papyrus; deciphered by Champollion in 1822 using the Rosetta Stone.
- Art: paintings like the Papyrus of Ani; jewellery, painted pots, woven sandals.
- Architecture: mastabas and pyramids, e.g. the Step Pyramid at Saqqara.

> Add a picture and 2–3 lines on why each was important.

🎉 **Chapter 4 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**